

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 7 6 5
♥ J 9
♦ J 8 5 2
♣ Q 10 4 2

♠ A Q 8 2
♥ K Q 2
♦ Q 6 4
♣ K 7 6



♠ K 3
♥ A 10 8 6 4
♦ 10 7 3
♣ J 8 3

♠ J 10 9 4
♥ 7 5 3
♦ A K 9
♣ A 9 5

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥6

East cannot play ♥s without setting up your ♥Q so he will probably exit with a ♣ which you take with the ♣K.

Play off your 6 winners and concede the last three tricks.

This was almost the same as Deal 5, the difference being in which direction the ♠ finesse had to be taken.

But it sure makes a big difference in how you play the hand.

This might have turned out even better. If East had decided to play his partner for the ♥Q, (who would have played ♥J from a holding of ♥ Q J x), you would have made an overtrick!

With his 4-3-3-3 distribution South chooses not to bother with Stayman. North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥6, dummy plays the ♥3 and West the ♥J.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=2 Total = 7

You need to get two more winners. The ♥ suit might provide one of them, but you will still have to establish ♠s. The burning question is whether to win the first ♥ or to hold up. If you take this trick you will have a second stopper if East takes the lead, but you will be in extreme danger if West takes the lead. Since the ♠ finesse has to go into East you should not hold up.

You win with your ♥K, (keeping East in the dark about who holds the ♥Q), enter dummy with the ♦A and play the ♠J, letting it ride to East's ♠K.

Board 2

East Deals

None Vul

♠ K Q 10 8 3

♥ 4

♦ J 8 7 3

♣ K 5 2

♠ 7 5 4

♥ 5 3

♦ A 9 5

♣ J 10 9 8 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ J 6

♥ K Q J 10 8 7 6

♦ 10 6 2

♣ 4

♠ A 9 2

♥ A 9 2

♦ K Q 4

♣ A Q 7 6

West

North

East

South

3♥

3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♥4

is no need to hold up. But . . . it couldn't hurt, could it?

Yes, it could hurt real bad! Suppose East has nothing in his hand but the ♥ K Q J 10 8 7 6 that you already know about. When you let his ♥10 win the first trick he will realize that his hand is dead. And he may be smart enough, (or lucky enough), to switch to a ♠.

The purpose of the hold-up play is to cut communications between the two defenders. So the general guideline is to hold up until you are sure one of the defenders is void in the suit - maybe twice, maybe only once, and in this case not at all.

But one of the important considerations you have to think about is the possibility that the Defense will switch to another suit - where you might be in even more trouble.

You'd feel bad on this hand if you let East hold the ♥10 only to see him next lay down the ♠J.

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥4, dummy plays the ♥3 and East the ♥10.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=1 Total = 6

You may not agree with South's 3NT bid but how else are you going to get to the only game that has a chance of making?

You need 3 extra winners and they will come from the ♣ suit even if West holds the ♣K and wins your finesse. You may think about holding up on the ♥A for one round just to make sure West has none if he wins the ♣K.

That would be a mistake. It is almost certain that East has a 7-card ♥ suit for his preemptive opening. This is confirmed by West's lead of the ♥4, with a doubleton he would have led a higher card. So there

Board 3

West Deals

E-W Vul

♠ 4
♥ A Q 10 2
♦ K 6 4
♣ K 10 8 6 3

♠ A K J 8 7 5

♥ 8 3

♦ 10 5 2

♣ A J



♠ 9 3
♥ J 9 5 4
♦ 8 7 3
♣ Q 7 4 2

♠ Q 10 6 2

♥ K 7 6

♦ A Q J 9

♣ 9 5

West	North	East	South
1 ♣	1 ♠	Pass	2 ♣
Pass	4 ♠		
All Pass			
4 ♠ by North			
Lead: ♣ 2			

South's 2♣ cue-bid shows a limit-raise or better in ♠s. North is to play 4♠. East leads the ♣ 2, dummy plays the ♣ 5 and West the ♣ K.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

You have one loser too many. If East holds either the ♥A or the ♦K this will be an easy contract, but West opened the bidding so he probably has most of the high cards. It does look like East holds the ♣Q based on his low lead and West's play to trick one.

Having gone through that thought process what is your Plan?

You will need to discard a loser on dummy's fourth ♦, but you must do so without ever letting East gain the lead since East is the defender who can lead through dummy's ♥K. And the only card that East can get the lead with is the ♣Q.

Hold-ups are usually used in notrump hands, but here you use one to prevent the Danger Hand from gaining the lead. Let West have the ♣K. He cannot play a red card without helping you so he will surely play another ♣.

Pull trumps in two rounds. Then play the ♦ 10 and let it ride.

West will win this but he is helpless. Whatever he plays you will be able to discard a ♥ loser on dummy's ♦.

The purpose of the hold-up play is to cut communications between the two defenders. Here you knew you would lose exactly one ♣ trick so you chose to lose it to West, the Safe Hand.

If you had taken the first ♣ trick West would have won your later ♦ finesse, put his partner on lead with the ♣Q and then swallowed up your ♥K.

Of course if East had been clever enough to lead a ♥ originally this Deal wouldn't be here.

Board 4
East Deals
None Vul

♠ 9 5 4 2
♥ 7 3
♦ A 8 4
♣ Q J 9 6

♠ Q 10 6
♥ K 8
♦ K Q 6 5
♣ 8 7 5 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 8 3
♥ Q J 10 6 4 2
♦ 7 3
♣ 4 2

♠ K J 7
♥ A 9 5
♦ J 10 9 2
♣ A K 10

West	North	East	South
Pass	3NT	2♥	2NT
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♥7			

South's 2NT overcall shows a 1NT opening hand with ♥s stopped. South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥7.

East plays the ♥10.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 4

You will need to establish both ♠ and ♦ winners. If East holds both these Aces along with 6 ♥s to the Q J then you are going down. But of course East can't have that good a hand, he opened with a Weak-2. So West has one of the Aces.

If you knew which Ace East held you could make sure you attacked that suit first but unfortunately you have no way of knowing that. So instead you resort to a hold-up.

East continues with the ♥Q.

West follows with the ♥3.

You let East have the first ♥ and won the next ♥ in dummy.

Start on ♦s next, maybe because they are longer. Assume that West holds the ♦A and takes it on the third round of the suit.

West glares at you, (because he has no ♥ to lead), and plays the ♣Q which you take with your ♣A. Next you score your ♦ winners and play a ♠, taken by East with the ♠A.

East glares at you, (because you still have the ♥A), and plays another ♥.

You take your 3 tricks and let West have the last ♣.

If you did not hold up on the first trick, but established ♦s first you would not have made the contract.

If you did not hold up on the first trick, but established ♠s first you would have made the contract even though you played incorrectly.

If you held up on the first trick you made the contract no matter which Ace West held.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ J 10 8 7

♥ 6

♦ K J 10 9

♣ J 9 8 4

♠ K 5 2

♥ A J 7 3

♦ A 8 3

♣ A 7 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 9 4 3

♥ K Q 10 9 5

♦ Q 4

♣ 10 5 2

♠ A Q 6

♥ 8 4 2

♦ 7 6 5 2

♣ K Q 3

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥K

that West is encouraging him to continue, just what you want.

Sometimes it works, sometimes it doesn't.

I sure hope that when you play this hand East falls for your Bath Coup.

Because if he doesn't you're going to have to end-play him.

Do you see how that might happen?

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥2 and West the ♥6.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 8

You just need one more winner and it could come from the ♦ suit if it happens to split 3-3. But you have another possibility. Suppose you let East hold the first trick and he decides to play another ♥? You would have two ♥ winners.

This isn't a true hold-up play although it does look like one. This play has the rather fancy name of Bath Coup, (named from Bath, England). Presumably East has led from ♥ K Q 10 9 5 and West has played his singleton ♥6. If East realizes that West has played his lowest card he will take that as a discouraging signal and will play a different suit. So you throw out your ♥7 rather than the ♥3. Now East may think